

Mock Interview Self-Reflection

Week 11 | Shantelle Wambui Kungu | September 2026

REFLECTION

The mock interview pushed me to articulate decisions I had made instinctively during development. When asked 'why XGBoost over a neural network for ClaimGuard?', I had the right answer - interpretability requirements, tabular data structure, training data size - but I reached for it too slowly. That hesitation signals I need to practise verbalising technical trade-offs under pressure, not just know them.

What went well: STAR responses for behavioural questions felt natural. When asked about a challenge I overcame, I described the SHAP NumPy 2.x compatibility issue clearly - problem, diagnosis, fix, lesson - without rambling. The interviewers noted the answer was specific and credible, which gave me confidence mid-session.

Where I need to improve: quantifying impact on the first attempt. I initially described ClaimGuard as 'reducing manual review time significantly' before being prompted to give a number. The number - 95% reduction, from 5-15 days to under 30 seconds - is compelling. I should lead with it, not arrive at it after a follow-up question.

My focus for real interviews: open every answer with the outcome, then explain the method. Numbers first. Narrative second. That order respects the interviewer's time and signals executive-level communication from the start.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- * Lead with quantified outcomes - 95% reduction, 28-day payback, AUC-ROC 0.84
- * Practise technical trade-off explanations out loud, not just internally
- * STAR structure is working - continue using it for all behavioural questions
- * Slow down on the first sentence; rushing signals nerves more than the content does